I- Reciprocal Trigonometric Functions

Definition

We define the functions *cosec* x, *sec* x, and *cot* x as the **reciprocal** functions of $\sin x$, $\cos x$, and $\tan x$ respectively :

$$\operatorname{cosec} x = \frac{1}{\sin x}, \qquad \sec x = \frac{1}{\cos x}, \qquad \text{and} \qquad \cot x = \frac{1}{\tan x} = \frac{\cos x}{\sin x}.$$

Example

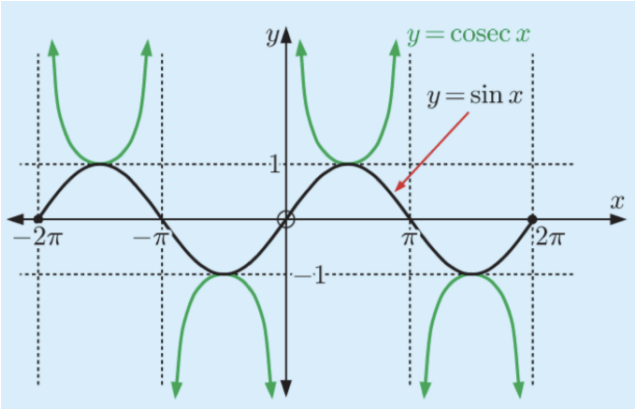
$$\operatorname{cosec} \frac{\pi}{6} = \frac{1}{\sin \frac{\pi}{6}} = \frac{1}{\frac{1}{2}} = 2.$$

Example

Using the graph of $y = \sin x$, sketch the graph of

$$y = \frac{1}{\sin x} = \operatorname{cosec} x \quad \text{for} \quad -2\pi \leqslant x \leqslant 2\pi.$$

Check your answer using technology.



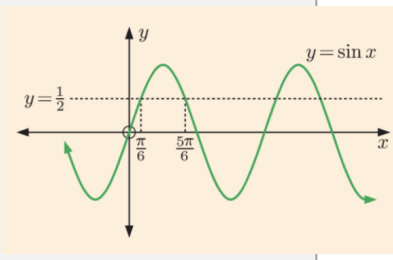
II- Inverse Trigonometric Functions

In many problems we need to know what angle results in a particular trigonometric ratio. We have previously seen this for right-angled triangle problems and when using the cosine and sine rules.

Rather than writing the inverse trigonometric functions as $\sin^{-1}$, $\cos^{-1}$, and $\tan^{-1}$, which can be confused with reciprocals, mathematicians more formally refer to these functions as the **inverse trigonometric functions** *arcsine*, *arccosine*, and *arctangent*.

Investigation

The function $y = \sin x$ fails the horizontal line test on its natural domain. For example, when $y = \frac{1}{2}$, there is more than one corresponding value of x, since $\sin x = \frac{1}{2}$ has infinitely many solutions, including



$$x = \frac{\pi}{6} \quad \text{and} \quad x = \frac{5\pi}{6}.$$

Therefore, if we want to find inverse functions for $\sin x$, $\cos x$, and $\tan x$, we will need to apply suitable domain restrictions.

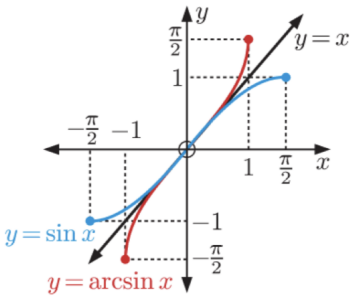
1. Draw the graphs of $y = \sin x$, $y = \cos x$, and $y = \tan x$ on the domain $-3\pi \leqslant x \leqslant 3\pi$.
2. Complete the following table, indicating whether each function is one-to-one on the given restricted domain.

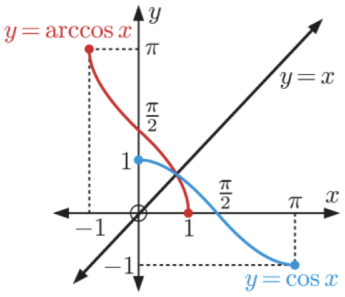
Restricted domain	$\sin x$	$\cos x$	$\tan x$
$0 \leqslant x \leqslant 2\pi$			
$-\pi \leqslant x \leqslant \pi$			
$-\frac{\pi}{2} \leqslant x \leqslant \frac{\pi}{2}$			
$0 \leqslant x \leqslant \pi$			
$-\frac{\pi}{2} \leqslant x \leqslant \frac{3\pi}{2}$			
$\pi \leqslant x \leqslant 2\pi$			

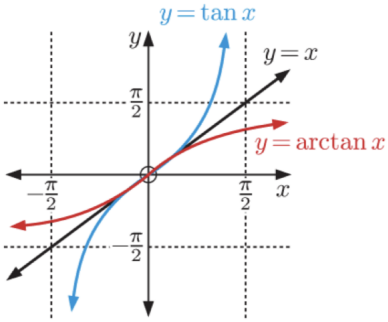
3. Discuss which domain restriction you think would be most suitable for the inverse function of :
   (a) $\sin x$
   (b) $\cos x$
   (c) $\tan x$
4. The function $f(x) = \sin x,\ -\frac{\pi}{2} \leqslant x \leqslant \frac{\pi}{2}$ has inverse $f^{-1}(x) = \arcsin x$. Sketch the graph of $y = f(x)$, and hence sketch the graph of $f^{-1}(x) = \arcsin x$ on the same set of axes.
5. The function $f(x) = \cos x,\ 0 \leqslant x \leqslant \pi$ has inverse $f^{-1}(x) = \arccos x$. Sketch the graph of $y = f(x)$, and hence sketch the graph of $f^{-1}(x) = \arccos x$ on the same set of axes.
6. The function $f(x) = \tan x,\ -\frac{\pi}{2} \leqslant x \leqslant \frac{\pi}{2}$ has inverse $f^{-1}(x) = \arctan x$. Sketch the graph of $y = f(x)$, and hence sketch the graph of $f^{-1}(x) = \arctan x$ on the same set of axes.

Definition

Inverse trigonometric function	Definition	Range
$y = \arcsin x$	$x = \sin y, \quad -1 \leqslant x \leqslant 1$	$-\frac{\pi}{2} \leqslant y \leqslant \frac{\pi}{2}$
$y = \arccos x$	$x = \cos y, \quad -1 \leqslant x \leqslant 1$	$0 \leqslant y \leqslant \pi$
$y = \arctan x$	$x = \tan y, \quad x \in \mathbb{R}$	$-\frac{\pi}{2} < y < \frac{\pi}{2}$







Example

Find, where possible, the exact solutions of :

1. $\arctan x = \frac{\pi}{3}$
2. $\arccos(x-1) = \frac{2\pi}{3}$
3. $\arcsin x = \frac{2\pi}{3}$